

Student Power Systems Documentation

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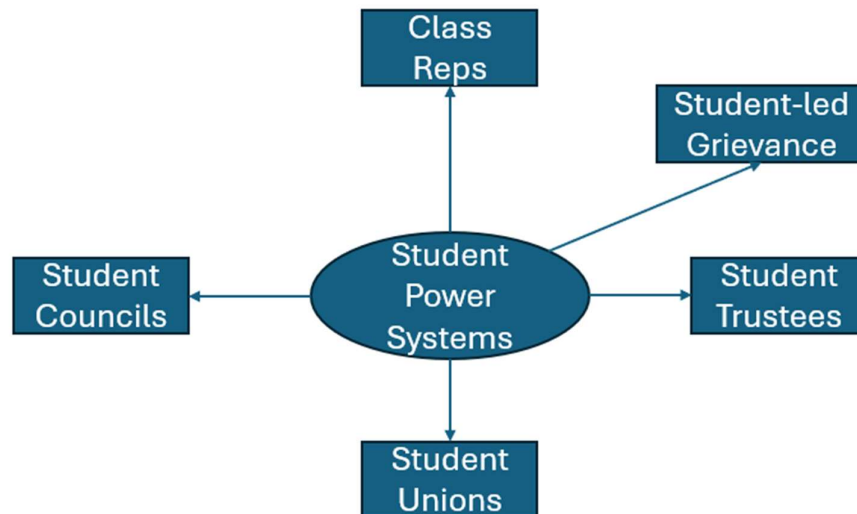
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Introduction

This Student Power System Documentation is designed to help schools implement student voice effectively throughout each layer of the education system. This is also designed to provide teachers and students with an understanding of how these power systems work so they know how they get a voice in the education system. This documentation was developed as currently schools do not give students a true voice in decisions affecting their safety and education. This documentation will cover student councils, student representatives, student unions, student trustees on governing boards and student-led grievance and reporting Systems. It will also provide a workflow for how these systems work together as well as the general trade-offs of each student power system.

This Student Power System cannot promise a perfect explanation, understanding or implementation. However, this documentation can promise to improve student power systems compared to the current solutions. It can also provide these student power systems in an easy-to-understand format. This documentation does not cover all current student power systems so please do not expect that of this documentation. Make sure to adapt this to school resources and to your own understanding.



The spider diagram shows the student power systems covered by this documentation. We can see here there is student trustees on governing boards and Student-led Grievance and reporting systems. This diagram does not show any of the features of the power systems. You can find more details in the sections below.

Class Representatives Section

- **Class representatives are students chosen to represent a specific class's educational needs.**
- **Class representatives should be elected by other classmates to make sure everyone in the class knows who is representing them.**
- **Class representatives should be given some time to prepare a speech for the class on why they should be class representatives.**
- **Class representatives should then during class be given the chance and time to present their speech to the class.**
- **The election is then done anonymously as classmates can vote for candidates through an anonymous voting system which then the teacher can read.**
- **This system shouldn't ask for name, email or track IP address just ask who the person is voting for.**
- **After all votes have been counted, the results are told to the students by the teacher.**
- **If the candidate does not want to represent, then the runner up candidate will be allowed to represent the class.**
- **The class representative can then push on class-specific needs to teachers or the student council.**
- **Class representatives will be able to meet with the members of the student council monthly to discuss class-specific needs.**
- **Class representatives can serve for about 1 academic year before an forced re-election.**
- **Class representatives should also have access to emotional/mental health support resources as their role can be stressful and exhaustive.**
- **If class representatives wish to quit at any point, they can report to a teacher like their form tutor anonymously.**
- **After the form tutor gets the quit response, an election is called where the same election process is repeated.**
- **The form tutor cannot tell the class why the class representative quit as that is private to that specific student.**
- **Classmates can also call for another election if most of the class agrees on it especially if the class representative hasn't been doing much for the class.**
- **This voting can be put forward by one student where an anonymous election can happen.**
- **These re-elections can only happen every month to prevent abuse of the system.**

Student Council Section

- **Student councils are a specific group of students that manages certain education decisions for the whole school across all year groups.**
- **Student council members are given time to prepare a speech for in front of the school or to upload digitally.**
- **Uploading digitally can be done where the candidates upload a speech document onto the school portal which can be seen and downloaded by other students.**
- **The digital upload is an option because it can extremely nerve-wrecking and even terrifying to have to read a speech in front of hundreds of people.**
- **Schools should aim to have multiple year groups in the student council to ensure that each year group is represented.**
- **Elections can take place over a few days and can be done via the anonymous voting system to make sure that students can vote for who they want.**
- **The votes will be counted by multiple teachers to prevent any bias with the results.**
- **After the votes are counted, the council members are told to all the students, and it is officially put on their record.**
- **However, if a council member does not want the role, then the candidate with the second most vote after the elected members will be given the opportunity to represent the school.**
- **After the election process is finished, student council members can work together to organise themselves into roles or choose to function without them.**
- **Council members can make proposals for decisions such as certain school rules, extracurricular clubs and school schedule.**
- **Once a proposal is agreed on by the student council, a faculty advisor can review it.**
- **This faculty advisor can only veto the proposal if it is harmful, breaks legal compliance or is unreasonable for school budget.**
- **If the faculty advisor vetoes the proposal without a valid and documented reason, the members of the student council can take the proposal to the principal or deputy head.**
- **There should also be an ethics committee that ensures that the student council is correctly representing the school and isn't keeping power for themselves.**
- **This ethics committee can be elected via the same election process used for the student council.**
- **The ethics committee members can review proposals and even take part in meetings to bring an ethical voice into the student council debates.**
- **However, the ethics committee is not allowed to call for an election without a valid documented reason that the student council is doing their job incorrectly.**
- **If the ethics committee and student council aren't doing their jobs or aren't representing the school properly, students can call for an election.**
- **This election can be approved if an majority of the student body agrees.**

Student Unions Section

- **Student Unions are independent, legally recognised organisations run by students at universities or colleges.**
- **Student Unions have their own constitutions, elected leadership and paid staff to provide collective bargaining power for students on issues like tuition fees and housing quality.**
- **Student union leadership should be elected annually in a fair election process.**
- **Candidates should be given time to prepare a speech to present in front of members in the union or upload it digitally.**
- **Students are then allowed to vote anonymously digitally or physically for their candidate.**
- **It is important to remember that anonymous digital systems are easier to implement compared to physical anonymous systems.**
- **After leadership is elected, they can debate over proposals affecting issues such as tuition fees, housing quality, academic policies, and welfare services.**
- **There should also be an ethics committee within the union.**
- **This ethics committee's role is to ensure that the union's leadership remains student-driven instead of politically driven.**
- **The ethics committee is elected via the same fair process as the student union leadership.**
- **They can review proposals, publish transparency reports on decisions that are made for the students in the union.**
- **If the ethics committee and union leadership still act with a politically driven approach to decisions, then students in the union if the majority agree can act.**
- **Students can act by calling for another election as a legal agreement in the terms of joining the union.**
- **Students must also pay mandatory student membership fees to the union if they are a member of it.**
- **They must pay mandatory student membership fees to the union as the unions has fees to pay for paid staff and other welfare services.**
- **However, there are 2 rules with membership fees.**
- **First, students should be able to opt-out of the union with a simple process.**
- **This can be done through a digital or physical process where the student must fill out an agreement that asks for information needed to leave the union.**
- **This agreement should ask for information such as name, reason (if they want to share it) and course (so they can quickly remove you).**
- **Second, students can ask for more time with payment fees if a valid reason occurs like a robbery or emergency.**
- **This is important because real life is unpredictable and students may not always have the money to pay the student membership fee immediately.**
- **These two rules should be student rights within the union's terms and conditions.**

Student Trustees on Governing Boards Section

- **Student Trustees on Governing Boards are voting members of a school, college or university's highest governing body alongside staff and community appointees.**
- **Student Trustees exist because they ensure that student perspective is present during high-level decisions about institutional strategy, budgets, and long-term planning.**
- **Governing boards should have a fair share of staff, community-appointees and student trustees to ensure fairness and equality in numbers.**
- **Student trustees should be given the time to prepare a speech to present to members of the student unions or upload digitally for them to see.**
- **The election should not be an appointment by student union leadership as members of the union deserve to have a say in who is representing them at the highest level.**
- **These elections should be done through anonymous digital and physical voting systems to prevent students from having to vote in fear.**
- **The votes are then counted by student union leadership, ethic committee members and community-appointed members.**
- **After votes are counted, the results should be told to the union members, and these student trustees have started their 1–2-year term.**
- **Student trustees are also able to quit or not represent as long as they inform the ethics committee or union leadership so a re-election can be called.**
- **Student trustees are then trained on basic OPSEC which includes learning how to filter out certain information and keep identities hidden online.**
- **These student trustees attend regular board meetings, receive confidential documents and vote on issues like tuition setting or capital projects.**
- **Confidential documents can be given to each group depending on the issues as student trustees can handle student-related issues while staff handle teacher-related issues.**
- **On the governing board, votes should be counted by 3 people with one person from each side to prevent bias and to ensure that all votes are counted fairly.**
- **Each side is given the chance to speak about their own side and their views on the proposal to ensure all voices are heard.**
- **There should also be an ethics committee made up of staff, students and community-appointed representatives to ensure that it is not bias.**
- **This ethics committee role is to make sure that the governing voting process is fair, to review proposals for harm, breaking legal compliance and unreasonable budget demands.**
- **The ethics committee members will receive training on ethical frameworks and will have access to data on budgets and legal requirements.**
- **Ethics committee members are elected via the same process as student union leadership and student trustees.**

Student-led Grievance and Reporting Systems Section

- **Student-led Grievance and Reporting Systems are formal processes, often guided by national-education laws, where students can report academic or welfare complains to a panel which includes student representatives.**
- **These systems are important because they address the power imbalances between students and staff in cases such as grading disputes, harassment allegations, or unfair treatment.**
- **Students can represent student judgement in these systems by volunteering or being elected by members of their student unions to do so.**
- **Once a student has been officially registered, they receive training in OPSEC, evidence assessment and procedural fairness.**
- **This training is important because students need to know how to decide consequences and get the correct result of an investigation.**
- **The process of a case should work efficiently and effectively.**
- **Both the defendant and the prosecution are given the opportunity to enter evidence to the system and make a statement for their case.**
- **The jury which is a mixture of staff and students will then assess the evidence entered and listen to the statements of both sides.**
- **After the evidence has been assessed and both sides have been heard, the jury in this case will be able to vote on a decision based on the evidence.**
- **This voting can take place digitally and anonymously so no one can retaliate based on who other members voted for. There should also be serious consequences for any physical or emotional retaliation.**
- **These consequences could include temporary ban from the jury, fines or even criminal records depending on the abuse.**
- **The decision is then presented to the room by one of the jury members and the solution or consequences are implemented.**
- **There should also be an ethics committee involved in this process as there needs to be an external watching making sure the process is fair.**
- **The ethics committee helps by reviewing the consequences or solutions given out by the jury and handles evidence securely in case of tampering by the members of the jury.**
- **Ethics committee members are elected by student union members or can voluntarily join the process if there is space.**
- **These members are then trained on ethical frameworks, OPSEC protocols, national legal requirements for education and evidence assessment.**
- **If a defendant or prosecution believes that the jury and ethics committee have ruled unfairly within valid reason. They should be able to make a request to have the case reviewed by another set of jury members.**
- **This should be within the rights of the defendant and prosecution as proceedings must be fair and just based on evidence and not just if you believe someone or not.**